RISING SON

The effect of Akbar's death on the general population, after almost half a century of rule, has been movingly described by Banarsi Das, an Agra merchant who was in Jaunpur at the time of the calamity. Most of those living in the empire at the time would have had no recollection of any Padshah other than Akbar. 'The alarming news of his death spread fast and soon reached Jaunpur,' wrote the merchant. 'People felt suddenly orphaned and insecure without their sire. Terror raged everywhere, the hearts of men trembled with dire apprehension, their faces became drained of colour.' Banarsi Das was so overcome by the news that, shaking and light-headed, he fell down a flight of stairs and smashed his head on the stone floor. His parents rushed to tend to him, and he was 'quickly put to bed with my sobbing mother at my side'. In the rest of the city…

> The whole town was in a tremor. Everyone closed the doors of his house in panic; shop-keepers shut down their shops. Feverishly, the rich hid their jewels and costly attire underground, many of them quickly dumped their wealth and their ready capital on carriages and rushed to safe, secluded places. Every householder began stocking his home with weapons and arms. Rich men took to wearing thick, rough clothes such as are worn by the poor, in order to conceal their status, and walked the streets covered in harsh woollen blankets or coarse cotton wrappers. Women shunned finery, dressing in shabby, lustreless clothes. None could tell the status of a man from his dress and it became impossible to distinguish the rich from the poor. There were manifest signs of panic everywhere although there was no reason for it since there were really no thieves or robbers about.

It was feared that without the Padshah's benevolent and powerful shadow over the country, chaos would ensue. The terror and insecurity are palpable in Banarsi Das's description, no doubt aggravated by the possibility of an outright war of succession, but so too is a genuine sorrow and distress. After ten days of anarchy and fear, the city breathed a sigh of relief when a proclamation arrived informing the populace that there was now a new